

Akshata Kumar
EXTC

Company: Mahindra Finance

Job Profile: Corporate Trainee (Data Science)

Offer Type: Placement Only

CTC: 16 LPA (14 LPA base + 2 L retention bonus)

Location: Pan India (mostly Mumbai)

Process Date:

PPT + Resume Shortlisting - 3rd September 2025

Aptitude test - 4th September 2025

Coding test - 19th September 2025

GD + PI - 3rd October 2025

NOTE: This was a **pool campus opportunity** along with VJTI so the entire process lasted a month. Be mentally prepared for such situations and set your priorities straight. Before this I participated in KPMG hiring process for the Tech Enablement role and it turns out I got selected, but due to a delay in their results I finally ended up with this opportunity.

Placement Process:

1. Pre-placement Talk

If you're seriously interested in a company, it's really important to attend the PPT and moreover, really pay attention to what exactly they are looking for, information about the role (location, CTC, I+P or not, etc.), company values and what they do. In this case, the role is that of **Corporate Trainee** and it has further categories like **Developer and Data Scientist** that they would decide based on our profiles.

- You can take note of things you find important and want to remember for interview rounds.
- In case of virtual PPTs, keep **screenshots of slides** with company values, their achievements, skills required etc.

2. Resume Shortlisting

This is a very crucial step and many deserving people sometimes fail to get their resume shortlisted (happened with me in certain initial companies) due to ignoring these basic points:-

- **CGPA!** Even though it cannot compensate for your lack of skills, maintaining a decent CGPA can definitely save you from being eliminated if the company has internal criteria for filtering out candidates. As far as I have seen, having a CGPA of **>7.5** is good enough and will make you eligible for all companies. However if you want to guarantee that they don't eliminate you from their side, **stay above 8** just in case. (Mine bordered around 7 which was a mistake on my part but I kinda made up for it through my resume and other areas, so luck is a big factor and if you don't have a good CGPA don't get demotivated because many companies look at your overall profile as well).

- **ATS!** Since it is unclear what the resume shortlisting criteria is for each company, do not think ATS score does not play a role. There may be times when HRs do not want to look through the resumes of 200-300 candidates so they simply filter on the basis of ATS score. So focus on increasing your resume's ATS score as much as you can (**>80 on Resume Worded** is great), and there are many techniques to do that by including stats, action words, **at least 1 work experience and 2-3 good projects** that actually add value, leadership roles, etc.)
- **JD!** Tailoring your resume according to the role and company you are applying for is really important, so please have a good look at the JD provided (things like skills required, role of intern, what the company does) and strategically include things that will give you an advantage when you talk about them during your interview. In my case, the role wasn't very specific like an SDE or DA or a non-tech role so what worked for me was showing versatility through projects and courses/certifications by adding **2 ML/Data Science related projects and 1 deployed fullstack project**. Also, I researched a bit about what the company's main business is and accordingly included an **AI-based loan underwriting agent project** for brownie points.

You can get a better idea through my resume that I used for Mahindra Finance:

 Akshata_Mahindra_Resume.pdf

3. **Aptitude Test** [~150 candidates got resume shortlisted and attempted this round]

This round was conducted on the YUGMA platform and consisted of **100 questions** (covering quants, aptitude, logical reasoning, verbal aptitude and behavioral/situation based questions) to be solved in **1 hour**. The challenge here was not in the difficulty of the questions but rather effective time management, and also the fact that each question had **negative marking** as well. I started from the beginning and had solved about 15-20 questions when I realised that there were so many questions to be done in a limited time. I then started solving the **behavioral and verbal questions** first as they were pretty easy and obvious to answer so they would secure marks, and after covering all those I moved on to the remaining quant questions which revolved around topics like **speed distance and time, percentage, profit loss, discounts**, etc. which were very doable. Practicing from **IndiaBix** is more than enough to prepare for aptitude based questions and I also think **quick strategising and presence of mind** really played a role here.

Keeping in mind the negative marking, I **left out 10 questions** which I was very unsure of. They had purposely included some very indecipherable questions where it wasn't clear what exactly needed to be done. All I can say is just trust your gut and if you really don't know what to do in a question, simply leave it (ofc only in OAs with negative marking). I think ppl who got **>70 questions correct** were selected after this round.

4. **Coding Test** [70 candidates shortlisted from previous round]

This was conducted on Assesshub and had **2 sections** :-

- The first section had **around 20 MCQs** on basic python input/output questions which are very doable if you know Python basics like **loops, variables, conditional operators**, etc.
- The second section had **3 DSA questions** (Leetcode easy level) to be solved in **Python** only. I was able to do these quickly, having been coding in Python since 1st year, but if you are a beginner you can practice with **Blind 75 sheet on Neetcode** as they have really good solution tutorials in Python.

It was a relatively easy coding round as compared to other OAs I had given before, but attention to detail was really important here since for output questions some options were very similar to each other so we

needed to read the code and each option properly. Also, the IDE for DSA questions was quite different to usual ones so we had to adapt our code according to the given main function.

I was able to solve **all 3 DSA questions and almost all MCQs correctly**, and I submitted way before the test ended so maybe both speed and accuracy could have been a factor behind shortlisting for next round.

5. **Group Discussion (GD)** [29 candidates shortlisted from previous round]

We were divided into **panels of 6** and I was in the first one. Before starting the GD, we were briefed about general rules to be followed and time guidelines (**9 mins for discussion + 1 min for concluding**).

The topic given to us was “**Technology : Boon or Bane**” and we were strictly told to be either for or against but not both. After getting the topic, we had a minute to gather and jot down our thoughts. Here, I prepared my points according to technology being a great boon since that is what I believe. However once the GD started, I was the 3rd person to speak up and everyone before me had spoken for the motion so I spontaneously decided to speak about technology being a bane and wrote down 2-3 points that came to my mind while others were speaking. While this could have been a mistake, I thought in the moment that if everyone speaks for the motion then it would be a very dull discussion with all of just saying “I agree with you...”, and I trusted in myself to speak on the spot without a lot of preparation so my communication skills helped me here. I presented a different viewpoint and was the only one who spoke against the motion (that possibly caught the interviewers’ attention).

6. **Personal Interview (PI)** [11 candidates shortlisted from previous round]

After getting shortlisted from GD, all of us had **2 interviews : technical and HR**, neither being eliminatory. They said they would take into account all our scores (aptitude, coding, GD, PI) and accordingly come up with a result in the end. Both the interviews were in no particular order and I had my HR round first:

- a) **HR** : This was a **45-minute long**, rigorous HR interview where the Head of HR basically wanted to assess our inner personalities and culture fit rather than technical prowess. She started with my family background, upbringing, what all places I have been to, etc. and also asked about which project taught me the most valuable life lessons and which one made me encounter the most challenges and self-doubts, with simultaneous follow-up questions for each. One important thing here was that I remembered their **DE&I (Diversity, Equity & Inclusion) framework** from the PPT and subtly included these values in my answers. She asked me a lot of questions about my life experiences and lessons I had learnt along the way to know what kind of a person I am. Towards the end I was also asked if I had come across any unethical practices around me and how I had reacted to them. As far as I could make out from her response to my answers, they look for people who know how and when to speak against something so it’s always good to have some answer for these questions. Even if you haven’t experienced something, have a presence of mind and think of the most suitable response rather than just saying “No” or “I don’t know”. Towards the end, she asked me if I had anything to ask her and since I had not really prepared for an HR-specific question I just asked “What are the company’s expectations from me in terms of beliefs and values if I get selected?” Again I reiterate, it is always better to have some decent response rather than saying “Nothing”.
- b) **Technical** : This interview also lasted around **40 minutes** and revolved around **technical and resume based questions** in depth. The interviewer was friendly and polite, starting with asking me for a brief introduction and then moving on to my projects and work experience. He focused more on

my 'Smart Returns' project and wanted to know how we decided on the problem statement and how exactly we were solving the problem at hand, what the end results are, detailed explanation of the project workflow and how different technologies are integrated together. He then went on to ask me about a case study along similar lines, it was regarding a **demand-based shipping** feature for orders on **Amazon**. I explained about a solution through data driven demand forecasting models to predict order volumes for a particular location depending on various factors like age group, economic capacity, geography, etc. He seemed satisfied with my response and asked me how accurate an ML model would be in such a case. I estimated a >80% accuracy since Amazon is a big company operating since long ago so they would have a large customer database hence we would get good accuracy through data analytics. He then asked me how we would handle the 20% inaccurate demand forecasting done by the ML model, and for this I suggested another feature so that the company's customer satisfaction rating and profitability do not get largely affected. He constantly tried to check if I was confident in my responses and finally seemed satisfied with my answer.

5 students got the final offer, and I was extremely grateful to be one of them.

Useful Tips:

1. Placements are one of the most trying yet important phases of life and you will definitely come out on the other side, a stronger and more confident person. This was my 6th process (OAs excluded!), so learn to take setbacks in a positive way and just keep preparing for your destined company.
2. ATS score checker : <http://resumeworded.com/> (try to get >80)
3. Python essentials : [Neetcode YT playlist](#) , [Blind 75](#) , Python for Everybody by University of Michigan (Coursera certification). Keep revising CS fundamentals (OS, CCN, DBMS, OOPs) as they are asked in a lot of tests and interviews both.
4. Aptitude : [IndiaBix](#) Start aptitude practice early on! Do not underestimate it or think "yeh toh easy hai ho hi jayega". Speed and accuracy only comes through consistent practice and you can't go from 0-100 in aptitude just in one night before your test.
5. For GDs, build your communication skills and quick thinking as they look for people who add value to the discussion by stating relevant points in a concise and articulate manner. The frequency honestly does not matter much, if you speak only 2 times but in a confident and agreeable manner then that would be better than hijacking the whole discussion and arguing with people.
6. On your interview day, remain calm and composed and meditate/listen to songs/think of God (whatever works for you). Try to focus more on the process rather than the outcome to stop overthinking and **believe in yourself!!!** Stop worrying about the result and just give your best and if it still does not turn out the way you wanted, there is something better in store for you.
7. Luck is a huge factor in every step of the process, so don't take failures personally and just keep trying and improving yourself every day.

Trust in God's plan, it will all work out well in the end.

For any queries, feel free to reach out to me through [LinkedIn](#)